IT

was a wintry afternoon on December 1 in Nagpur when Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) *sarsanghchalak* Mohan Bhagwat took the stage and called upon Indian (Hindu) couples to do their patriotic duty—have at least three children. The RSS chief, known for his Hindutva musings and cultural prescriptions, painted a grim picture: "According to population science, when growth is below 2.1, a society perishes on its own. Nobody destroys it." He was referring to the total fertility rate (TFR), the benchmark for population replacement. At a TFR of 2.1, each woman on average would have two children to sustain the population at a stable level. With India's TFR now at 2, the RSS chief felt a demographic decline had to be averted—hence the call for larger families.

It may sound like fear-mongering considering India is the world's most populous country now, but the RSS chief's concerns are not unique. Far to the south in Tamil Nadu, Chief Minister M.K. Stalin has voiced similar worries, lamenting the potential consequences of a shrinking population. In neighbouring Andhra Pradesh, CM N. Chandrababu Naidu has gone a step further, contemplating legislative incentives to encourage larger families.

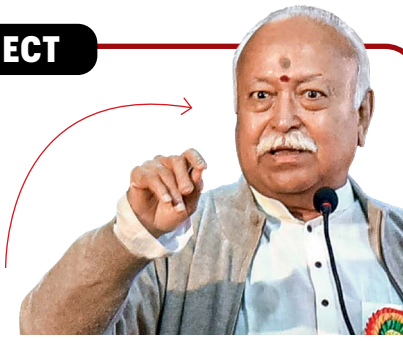
Behind these leaders' statements is a shared fear of loss, albeit in different domains. For Stalin and Naidu, the apprehension revolves around political representation and loss of funds. With parliamentary delimitation set for 2026—a process that will redraw constituencies based on population—the balance of power could tilt further towards northern states with higher fertility rates. Southern states, once lauded for their successes in population control, now worry about losing representation in the Lok Sabha. Revenue-sharing formulas tied to population metrics have added to the disgruntlement at being "penalised" for their achievements.

Bhagwat's concerns, meanwhile, appear more existential. His appeal aligns with a narrative prevalent in Hindutva circles: that the Muslim population is growing faster than the Hindu one, potentially altering the demographic balance. Studies, like the one by the Economic Advisory Council to the prime minister (EAC-PM) in May 2024, have fuelled this sentiment. While the gap between Hindu and Muslim growth rates has narrowed over the decades, the study highlighted a decline in the Hindu population share from 84.7 per cent in 1950 to 78.1 per cent in 2015, alongside an increase in the Muslim share from 9.8 per cent to 14.1 per cent. However, experts and organisations like the Population Foundation of India have underscored a far more nuanced demographic picture than what the numbers suggest.

A NEW PEOPLE PROJECT

2
India's current fertility rate; may go down to 1.3 by 2050

3
No. of children Indian (read Hindu) couples should have, as per RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat



8.3
percentage point drop in Muslim growth rate, from 32.9% (1981-91) to 24.6% (2001-11). For Hindus, it was 5.9 percentage points, down from 22.7% to 16.8%

1.7 bn
India's population to peak in 2054; may slide to 1.5 bn by 2100

Source: National Commission on Population, MoHFW; 2011 Census, population projections

DO WE NEED MORE BABIES?

With 1.5 billion people, projections from the United Nations' World Population Prospects 2024 report suggest that India's population will peak at 1.7 billion by 2054 before declining to 1.5 billion by the end of the century (see *A New People Project*). This means that even after 75 years, India's population will remain where it is now. Global population experts see stabilising growth not as a threat but as an opportunity to shift focus toward improved health, education and living standards. "After it peaks, any decline in population size is expected to be gradual and negligible, posing no risk of extinction," says Andrea M. Wojnar, the UNFPA (United Nations Population Fund) India representative.

India's demographic crossroads present both a challenge and a historic opportunity, depending on how the country navigates this period of transition. "The big question is, do we have an optimal number in mind for the ideal population? India began a massive population control programme in the 1970s when it was 650 million. Today, we are at 1.4 billion and will reach about 1.7 billion by 2054. If we thought 650 million was too large in the 1970s, why do we think 1.7 billion is too small today?" asks Sonalde Desai, professor of sociology at the University of Maryland.

On the surface, some numbers may present a grim picture: India's population growth is slowing, the TFR has dropped to 2.0, and many states have fertility levels far below the replacement threshold of 2.1. These shifts mirror crises seen elsewhere in the world, such as Japan and South Korea, where declining fertility has triggered shrink-